

Letter of Inquiry

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To study the diffusion or discussion of misinformation on social media, computational researchers commonly rely on tracking blacklisted domains (González-Bailón et al., 2023; Guess et al., 2020; Grinberg et al., 2019). Recent research published in top-tier journals has identified misinformation based on a domain-list curated by the organization NewsGuard, e.g., Robertson et al. (2023). However, the database is proprietary and only validated for the U.S. context by Lin et al. (2023). Therefore, this proposal outlines a descriptive review of the NewsGuard list over time and across contexts, and is guided by the question: How reliable is the NewsGuard list to measure misinformation online?

What is being described?

NewsGuard applies an expert-based approach; analysts assign ratings based on nine distinct criteria and regularly update these assessments. For the U.S. context, the lists has shown high agreement with other expert-rated lists (Lin et al., 2023), but it is crucial to assess the usefulness of this list for research beyond the English-speaking world. Moreover, there are several challenges associated with NewsGuard: First, the domain ratings were initially created as a tool for brand security rather than a research instrument, which is why the list is proprietary and access as well as publication of the data is restricted. Second, the list is updated in unknown intervals, which is why it is important to understand the update process of the ratings. Third, the list is not exhaustive, and the coverage changes over time and for the selected countries. Finally, the list contains missing data points, and it is unclear how this would affect the results of a study. Consequently, we propose to provide a comprehensive description of this database over time (from 2019 until today,

in monthly granularity) and across countries provided by NewsGuard. We believe that is essential to address the following aspects of the database:

- a) the distribution, construction, weighting and update process of the ratings,
- b) the selection and removal of sources, and
- c) the completeness and reliability of other information provided in the database, e.g., political orientation.

In addition, we reproduce published research relying on the NewsGuard list with different versions of the list to assess the degree to which results depend on a specific version of the list.

How is the sample constructed?

How does it pertain to digital media?

The reach of misinformation on the general population has been debated (Watts et al., 2021), with only a small number of people engaging with misinformation online (Allen et al., 2020; Grinberg et al., 2019). Yet, when judging the consequences of the problem at the scale of the information ecosystem, misinformation seems to feed into growing partisan sorting and intergroup animosity (González-Bailón et al., 2023; Robertson et al., 2023). Misinformation is widely visible on social media and in the mainstream media (Tsfati et al., 2020), because it exploits the dynamics at play by fueling intergroup conflict and negative emotions. Consequently, to understand the spread of misinformation on digital platforms, it is imperative for computational social scientists to have access to reliable and valid data. By reviewing strategies to research misinformation online, and assessing the reliability of source-based approaches in particular, we outline potential drawbacks and pitfalls for digital media research and offer recommendations for the application of the NewsGuard database in different contexts.

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